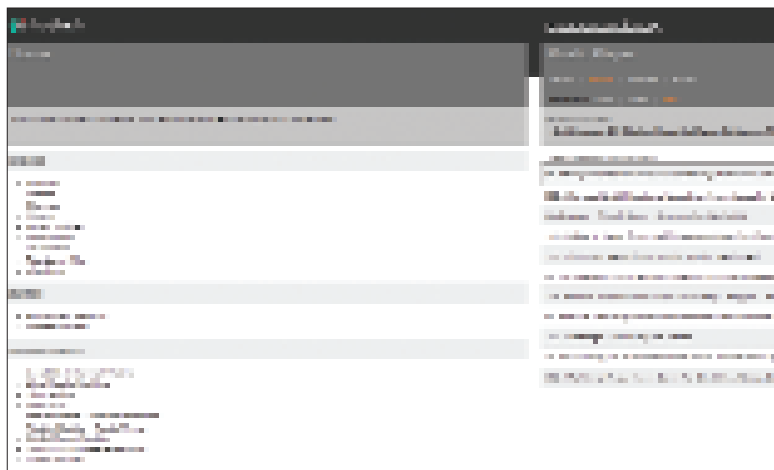


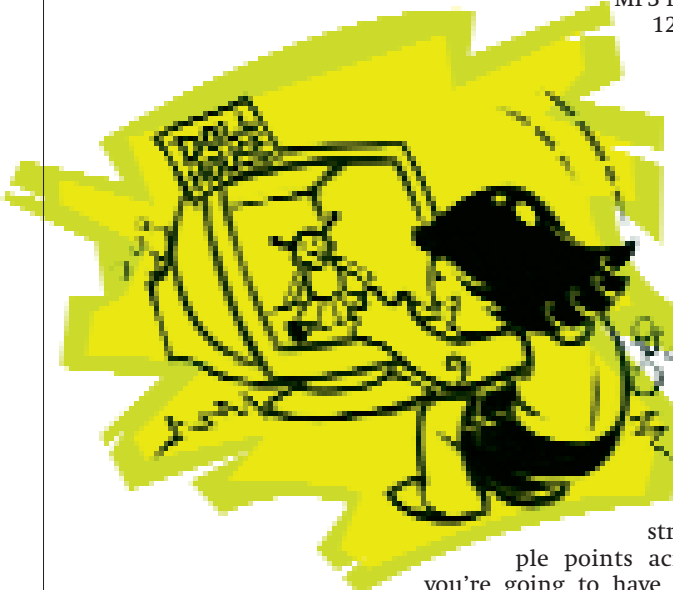


Using SlimServer to stream audio to many computers on your LAN

keeps changing—you can install software from [www.dyndns.com](http://www.dyndns.com) to get yourself a fixed URL to connect to, no matter how many times your PC's IP address changes.

### Take Me To The Movies

When it comes to video streaming over a LAN, nothing beats VLC Media Player. Video streaming is not as easily achieved as a LAN Radio—that's because of the vast differences in file sizes and streaming bit rates. Converting an MP3 from 320 Kbps to



128 Kbps and streaming is hardly noticeable by anyone. Video is another ball-game. If you want to be able to pick and choose which video you want to watch, just settle for a file server. If you actually want a movie or video to be streamed to multiple points across your LAN, you're going to have to use the VLC Wizard to set up streaming. It's child's play, really: just go to File > Wizard, select Stream to network, select the file or disc you want to stream, select a protocol to stream over, and when you finish the Wizard, your file starts streaming. Keep an eye open for the tips that will tell you how to access the stream—for example, if you chose the HTTP protocol, your stream will be available on [http://<your\\_ip>:8080](http://<your_ip>:8080), and this is where you have to point your media player in order to watch the video. Although there are some software that offer to stream video online, you need pretty good configuration servers to serve multiple videos to multiple PCs, and that sort of defeats the purpose...

### Download That

What's most of the world's bandwidth being used on? Torrent downloads. Let's not get into the legalities here, but suffice it to say, if you've got broadband, you're using BitTorrent to download anything from Linux distros to illegal pirated content. We'll save the lectures for another time, but why let your new monster PC stay awake all night working when you've got an old PC that uses half the power? Now there are two ways in which you can set this up. You either use Linux (Ubuntu) and Azureus' Web interface to set up a torrent box that you can add downloads to from anywhere in the world, or just use Azureus on Windows and your local LAN. Those of you willing to try the Linux option should visit <http://nerdica.com/?p=30> for a complete tutorial on how to set this up.

For our Windows fans out there, we'll tell you our way.

Our choice is µTorrent; it's tiny, uses low system resources and has a beta version out that includes a Web interface. It also monitors a preset folder and automatically downloads any torrent files you add to the folder. Here's what you need to do in order to get this running.

First, go to [www.utorrent.com](http://www.utorrent.com) and download their Web UI beta. The direct download link, as of writing this article is [http://download.utorrent.com/beta/webui\\_v0.310\\_beta\\_2.rar](http://download.utorrent.com/beta/webui_v0.310_beta_2.rar) (275 KB), but this might change. By the time you read this, the stable release might incorporate the Web interface, so look on the µTorrent site for information regarding the Web UI beta.

Once you have downloaded the file, you will need WinRAR ([www.rarlab.com](http://www.rarlab.com)) to uncompress the file. After uncompressing, you will find a folder, a readme, a zip file and the µTorrent installer. First install µTorrent using the installer. After you have done this, copy the webui.zip file and then press [Windows] + [R] (or Start > Run), type in "%AppData%\uTorrent" and press [Enter]. This will take you to the "C:\Documents and Settings\<User>\Application Data\uTorrent\" folder, where you should see a file called settings.dat. Paste the webui.zip file into this folder and then close it.

Now start µTorrent and go to Options > Preferences ([Ctrl] + [P] in the µTorrent window). Under Advanced, you will find Web UI. Click on this and on the right you should see a checkbox titled Enable Web Interface. Tick this and then add a username and password of your choice. If you want your friends to be able to add torrents, you can also select Enable Guest account with username. You can provide a unique username for guest accounts, and make sure you do not leave it as "guest" if you enable it. Next, you should also tick the Alternative listening port box and add a port of your choice here. If you don't know what to add, the default 8080 will do fine.

If you want to be able to access this service from outside your LAN (from anywhere on the Net), leave the "Restrict access to the following



### Tips

Because a lot of the uses mentioned here require hard drives—file server, LAN radio, FTP server, etc.—it's not wise to use an old computer's hard drive to store critical data. Especially for cases like the file server or FTP server, where the stored files might be of appreciable importance, the death of a hard drive can be disastrous. We strongly urge that if you use your old computer, make sure the hard drive is functioning well, or even buy a new one to put your data at the lowest possible risk. In cases such as the media server or LAN radio, where your digital media collection is at stake, make sure to keep a backup of your media collection on your primary PC—copy the files to the old PC instead of moving them there.

IPs" field blank. If you only want only your LAN IPs to access the µTorrent Web interface, add the IP addresses of computers on your LAN here.

That's it—you're all set. You will now be able to access the Web UI of µTorrent from your LAN or over the Net—depending on the setting you chose. In order to do so, open a browser window, type in [http://<your\\_ip>:<port>/gui/](http://<your_ip>:<port>/gui/)—where <your\_ip> is your LAN IP when accessing from within your network, or your public Internet IP when accessing remotely over the Net. If you're using the same computer to test the Web UI, use 127.0.0.1 as the IP. For the <port> setting, you have to use whatever you configured earlier—8080 in our case.

You will be given a username and password prompt. Enter the appropriate values here and then you should have access to your µTorrent Web UI. From here you can view the status of downloading files and even add new torrents for download. You can even provide a torrent's URL, and let µTorrent fetch the .torrent itself.

Interestingly, there's also another way to get µTorrent to automatically start downloads. In the µTorrent Preferences, click on Other and you should see an option for Auto-Load Torrents. Here you can specify a folder that µTorrent will monitor. If any torrent files are added to this folder, µTorrent will automatically start the download and delete or rename the torrent. Now, what you can do is share this same folder that you set here over your LAN—make sure to use a dollar share—and check the "Allow network users to change my files" option. Now all you have to do is tell people on your LAN to save the torrent file of any download that they want to queue into this folder, and voila—an automatic download box. Remember, this only works on the LAN.

If you have a limited bandwidth connection, you might not want to share your Web UI password with anyone, or you might soon end up with rather large bills!

### Rather Handy

It seems to be quite a waste—in terms of power—to run just one of the above-mentioned functions on your old PC. We suggest you choose at least three of the above uses for that old PC in order to justify the consumption of somewhere near 200 W of power—hard drives, fans, CPU, RAM, etc. If you're increasing your power bill, make sure the PC adds enough value to justify being on 24/7.

As we've mentioned earlier, these are just guidelines for a few ways in which that old PC can be put back into service. While raising the dead, let us know if you have any interesting anecdotes or wacky ways in which you use your old PCs—we love to hear about them! ■

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